

SCHOOL OF LIFE FOUNDATION

The Architecture of *Grace*



BOOK THREE · THE INTERIOR

Autism-Adapted Edition

Visual Anchor Charts

TEACHER SUPPLEMENT

Grades 6–8 · Middle School

Designed for autistic learners with moderate support needs

Twelve printable anchor charts · One per page

Selected core charts · Adult co-regulation model · Crisis resources prominent

Before You Begin

What Book Three looks like at moderate support needs

This supplement is the most carefully scoped of the three moderate-support-needs books — and we want to be honest with you about that scope.

Architecture of Grace · *Book Three* contains twenty-eight lessons organized around concepts requiring substantial abstract reasoning: **Mask vs. Mirror, the Compassionate Witness, Frankl’s Choice-Agency, Mercy vs. Justice, the Grace Gap audit**. For moderate-support-needs students at Grades 6–8, several are not developmentally appropriate. Pretending otherwise would be a disservice.

The multidisciplinary team made the following scope decisions:

What we kept and adapted (12 charts)

- **Mask vs. Mirror** — with the autistic burnout panel prominent. The most important chart in this book.
- **Shame vs. Guilt · Mean vs. Helpful Thoughts · When I Made a Mistake** — preserved as concrete first-then structures.
- **The Pause / Charitable Interpretation** — replaced with the “When Something Surprises Me” co-regulation routine.
- **Forgive ≠ Be Close Again** — Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation, with pattern guardrail.
- **Hard Person vs. Unsafe Person** — concrete observable criteria.
- **Asking for What I Need** — accommodation requests as a self-advocacy skill.
- **Crisis Resources (appears twice)** — with autism-specific panel. *Non-negotiable*.

What we chose to omit

- Compassionate Witness as a third-person voice; Choice-Agency Map with three rings; Mercy vs. Justice as a held tension; Grace Gap audit project; Letter of Release as a class writing task; several wrap-up lessons.

The result: twelve substantive charts at this support level — not 28 of declining quality.

A NOTE ON SCOPE

A student who is at moderate support needs in one domain may be at lower support needs in another. If a moderate-support-needs student’s abstract reasoning is stronger than this supplement assumes, the lower-support-needs *Book Three* may be more appropriate — or some combination. *Trust your read of the student in front of you.*

How I Have to LOOK · How I AM

Mask vs. Mirror · Performing vs. real

THE MASK · HOW I LOOK



What I show outside.

The performance.

THE MIRROR · HOW I AM



What is true inside.

The real me.

FOR AUTISTIC STUDENTS

Sometimes we try to LOOK like everyone else — even when it costs us a lot inside.

This room is a place where you can be how you ARE.

You can stim. You can look away. You can be quiet. You don't have to perform.

*Performing all the time is **tiring**.
You are allowed to **rest** from the performance.*

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Sometimes we wear a mask — we look one way on the outside, even when we feel different on the inside. That is okay sometimes. But it is also tiring. In this room, you can show how you really are. You can stim. You can be quiet. You can take a break. You don't have to perform.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This is the single most important chart in this book. For moderate-support-needs autistic adolescents, masking pressure is real — often delivered through years of behavioral intervention that taught compliance and “quiet hands.” The chart explicitly says: this room is different. The autistic burnout literature applies just as much to moderate-support-needs students as to those with lower support needs; possibly more, because they have fewer alternatives. Read the panel aloud as part of the lesson. Post Day 1. Keep all year.

What I DID · Who I AM

Guilt vs. Shame · Two different things

WHAT I DID



“I made a choice that didn’t work.”

Can be fixed.

“WHO I AM”



“I am bad.”

Never true about a person.

You did a thing.

*You are **not** a bad thing.*

FOR ANYONE TOLD “YOU ARE BAD”

They are **wrong**.

Being autistic is not being bad.

Being different is not being broken.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“There is a difference between what we DID and who we ARE. Mistakes are about what we did — they can be fixed. ‘I am bad’ is not true about anyone. Some people in your life may have told you something is wrong with WHO you are. They were wrong. You are still you.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

By Grade 6, moderate-support-needs autistic students have often heard a decade of identity-level feedback — often delivered as well-meaning behavior correction. The plain-words box names this directly. Read aloud. Some students may have very still or absent reactions to this — note privately, follow Disclosure Protocol if needed.

Mean Thoughts vs. Helpful Thoughts

The Internal Critic · A Compassionate Witness

WHAT THIS MEANS

We all have two kinds of thoughts inside our heads.
We can **notice** them. We can **choose** the helpful one.

MEAN THOUGHTS



“I always mess up.”
“Everyone hates me.”
Big words. Catastrophic.

HELPFUL THOUGHTS



“This was hard.”
“What can I do next?”
Honest. Kind.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Listen to your thought. Is it a MEAN thought or a HELPFUL thought? (point to chart) Mean thoughts say BIG words — always, never, everyone. Helpful thoughts say what was true — and what we can do next. We can pick the helpful one.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Original “Internal Critic vs. Compassionate Witness” replaced with the same naming used in Books 1 and 2 — “Mean Thoughts vs. Helpful Thoughts.” Consistent language across grade bands matters for moderate-support-needs students. Color-code red/green. Post permanently.

When I Made a Mistake

Accountability — not punishment

1

What did I DO?

Say it honestly.

2

What was the HURT?

Even if I didn't mean it — the hurt is real.

3

What can I FIX?

Pick one thing. Do it.

4

Then — DONE.

You did the work. The bad feeling can stop.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Four steps. Say what you did. Say the hurt. Fix what you can. Then — you are done. Feeling bad longer than that is not the same as fixing it. You already fixed it.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Step 4 — “then DONE” — is essential for moderate-support-needs students with strong justice-sensitivity who will keep punishing themselves past repair. The chart explicitly says: you can stop now. Adapted from the Three-Part Accountability Map. Walk through slowly.

Crisis Resources

Post visibly before students arrive · Keep posted all year

988 — Suicide & Crisis Lifeline

Call or text 988

Crisis Text Line — text HOME to 741741

YOUR SCHOOL COUNSELOR

Name: _____

Where to find them: _____

A NOTE FOR AUTISTIC STUDENTS

Sometimes autistic teenagers feel like life is too hard.

Your life matters. The way you are is not the problem.

If talking is hard — **text HOME to 741741**. You can use text.

You can also point to this chart and show a grown-up.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“This chart will stay on the wall all year. If you ever feel like life is too hard — you can show this chart to a grown-up. You can also call or text 988. If talking is hard for you, you can text HOME to 741741. You don’t have to talk. You don’t have to do this alone.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Autistic adolescents — including those at moderate support needs — face elevated suicide risk. For moderate-support-needs students specifically, the inability to verbally articulate distress can mean crisis is missed until it becomes a behavioral emergency. The chart includes an explicit pointing instruction (“show a grown-up the chart”) because pointing may be the most accessible help-seeking behavior. The text option is named. Crisis resources stay posted all year. Counselor physically in room before any student arrives.

Forgive ≠ Be Close Again

Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation

FORGIVE



Put down the heavy feeling.

For ME.

BE CLOSE AGAIN



A separate choice.

Only if it is SAFE.

*You can **forgive** someone
and still choose **not to be close** to them again.*

PATTERNS ARE INFORMATION

One hard thing + real change = okay.

The same hurt over and over = a pattern. Trust it.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Forgiving and being close to someone again are not the same. Forgive = put the heavy feeling down. Be close = let them back in. You can forgive someone — and still keep them far away. If they keep hurting you, that pattern is real. You are allowed to notice it.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original chart uses “reconciliation” — replaced with “be close again” for accessibility. The pattern-tracking guardrail is essential for moderate-support-needs adolescents, who are particularly vulnerable to repeated harm and who may have been trained to give endless second chances as a compliance routine.

When Something Surprises Me

What I do before I react



STOP

Take a breath. Do not react yet.



GO SOMEWHERE SAFE

A quiet place. A trusted person.



CHECK MY BODY

Am I calm enough to think? If no — wait. Regulate first.



CHOOSE WHAT TO DO

With a trusted person if I need help.

IF IT KEEPS HAPPENING — TELL A GROWN-UP

A pattern of hurt is real. **Your read is data.**

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“When something surprises you — stop. Go somewhere safe. Check your body — are you calm enough to think? If not, wait. Then choose what to do next. You don’t have to do it alone. If the same hurt keeps happening — tell a grown-up.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Combines the original Flame vs. Pause (U3·L4) and Charitable Interpretation (U4·L3) into a single concrete co-regulated routine. **Step 3 — Check my body — is critical:** for many moderate-support-needs students, regulation is the prerequisite for the Pause, not the goal of it. The pattern guardrail is preserved. Post permanently from U3·L4 forward.

Crisis Resources · Reminder

Same chart as Unit 2 · Lesson 6 · Re-post for this lesson

988 — Suicide & Crisis Lifeline

Call or text 988

Crisis Text Line — text HOME to 741741

A REMINDER

Your life matters. The way you are is not the problem.

If talking is hard — text HOME to 741741.

You can also point to this chart and show a grown-up.

FOR THIS LESSON

This lesson (the “Letter of Release”) can bring up hard feelings.

You do not have to do the writing in front of the class.

You can ask to do it with the counselor instead.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Today’s lesson can be hard. The crisis resources are still on the wall. You can text 988 or HOME to 741741. You can also point to this chart and show me. You do not have to write the letter in front of the class — you can ask to write it with the counselor.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original U3·L6 Letter of Release lesson is high-risk for moderate-support-needs students — the unstructured private writing can surface disclosures of harm, and moderate-support-needs students may not have language to flag distress in the moment. The added “do it with the counselor instead” option preserves the lesson’s purpose while moving the high-risk writing to a 1:1 counselor session. Coordinate with counselor before lesson day.

Asking for What I Need

Limits · Accommodations · Self-respect

A LIMIT IS

Telling someone what I need to feel okay.
Not a punishment. Not a fight. Just information.



“I need my headphones.”



“I need a break.”



“I need to step out.”



“I need a quiet person.”

Asking for what you need is **not** rude.
It is **information** the grown-ups around you can use.

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“You are allowed to ask for what you need. Headphones, a break, a quiet place, a trusted person — these are not special favors. They help you do the work. Telling us what you need is a skill. We want to know.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Original “Limits” lesson framed as accommodation requests — which is exactly what they are for autistic students. Many moderate-support-needs students have been trained, often unintentionally, that asking for sensory accommodations is asking for special treatment; the chart explicitly reframes this as “information the grown-ups can use.” Print the four choice cards for the student’s desk. Post permanently.

What Is Grace?

A kind choice — not a rule

WHAT GRACE IS

Being kind to someone — even when they did **not** earn it.
A choice. Not a rule.



EASY
kind person



HARDER
neutral person



HARDEST
difficult person

GRACE HAS LIMITS

You do **NOT** have to give grace to someone who keeps hurting you.
“Difficult” is not the same as “unsafe.”

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Grace = being kind to someone even when they didn’t earn it. It is something we CHOOSE. Grace toward kind people is easy. Grace toward a difficult person is harder. Grace toward someone who keeps hurting you is NOT required. Safety first.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The “Grace has limits” panel is non-negotiable. Many moderate-support-needs students at this age have been told repeatedly to “be the bigger person” toward people actively harming them. The chart explicitly says: difficult ≠ unsafe, and grace toward unsafe people is never required. Continues into U4·L5 (Difficult vs. Unsafe).

Hard Person · Unsafe Person

Difficult vs. Unsafe · A working test

HARD PERSON



Annoying. Different.

I leave okay. Grace is possible.

UNSAFE PERSON



Hurts me again and again.

I leave smaller. Protect myself.

THE TEST

Hard: annoying — but I am okay after.

Unsafe: I feel smaller, scared, or hurt — and it keeps happening.

*Grace is **not required** toward an unsafe person.*

Adult Script · What the Grown-Up Says

“Hard people are annoying — but you are okay after them. Unsafe people make you feel smaller — and they keep doing it. That is the test. With a hard person, you can practice grace. With an unsafe person, you protect yourself. Tell a trusted grown-up.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The concrete working test is essential. Many moderate-support-needs students cannot easily abstract the difference between difficult and unsafe; they CAN evaluate “do I leave okay or do I leave smaller” applied to a specific person. This is one of the most protective charts in the book — make sure it lands. Keep posted.

A Note to the Teacher

What Book Three at moderate support needs asks of you

You are teaching the most cognitively and emotionally demanding section of the curriculum to students whose access to abstract reasoning is more limited than the curriculum's default audience. The team has been honest about scope: **twelve substantive charts, deeply adapted, rather than twenty-eight charts of declining quality.**

For moderate-support-needs students at Grades 6–8, masking pressure can be intense — often delivered through years of behavioral intervention that taught compliance over self-expression. Watch for the cost. Listen for what is not being said. **You may be the only adult who notices that a student who looks fine is not.**

What we ask you to honor

- **Unmasking is welcome in your room.** Stims, looking away, fidgets, quiet — all are forms of presence.
- **The Pause requires regulation first.** A dysregulated nervous system cannot execute four steps. The chart returns when the body returns.
- **Asking for accommodation is a skill, not a deficit.** Welcome it.
- **Patterns of harm are real.** A student who points to the chart again and again about the same person is naming a pattern.
- **"Difficult" is not "unsafe."** Grace toward unsafe people is never required.

What we ask you to never do

- Never tell a moderate-support-needs student to "give more grace" to someone repeatedly hurting them.
- Never require the Letter of Release to be written in front of the class. Coordinate with counselor for individual completion.
- Never assume a quiet moderate-support-needs student is calm. They may be in shutdown.
- Never frame masking as growth. It is survival behavior with documented cost.

A FINAL WORD

The original *Architecture of Grace · The Interior* is serious work, built on solid research. This moderate-support-needs supplement exists because moderate-support-needs adolescents deserve access to the same core protections — Mask vs. Mirror, the safety floor, accommodation as a skill, the difficult/unsafe distinction — even when the full conceptual architecture is not developmentally accessible. *Thank you for the work you do. It matters more than the day will let you see.*